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Senate of Virginia Floor Session, Tuesday, January 20, 2026

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- Official floor video (Senate of Virginia, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qS37nE3M2W0
- LIS Senate minutes: https://lis.virginia.gov/session-details/20261/minutes-list/S

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[00:24:57] The Senate will come to order. The Senators will please take their seats.

[00:26:12] Those persons not entitled to the privilege of the floor will retire to the gallery. The Senators and all in attendance, please stand if you're able. We will be led in prayer by Chaplain Martin Lee from Isle

of Wight Sheriff's Office in Smithfield.

[00:26:30] And following the prayer, everyone will please remain standing and be led in the Pledge of Allegiance to the flag of the United States of America by Senate Page Raquel Rice-Weber from Dinwiddie. Join me in prayer, please.

[00:26:50] Almighty God, Heavenly Father, Lord of our glory, we come to you and offer praise for your majesty, grace, and power. We stand in awe of your majesty and of your grace. We humbly ask that your Holy Spirit guide us, open our hearts to your word. As we gather to conduct the affairs of our great state, we ask that you direct our paths, grant our legislators wisdom to make sound decisions, to discern good from evil, and lead effectively.

[00:27:16] We ask you bless this group of individuals selected to lead our state and give them compassion and understanding. May you protect their travels and their families as they traverse this great state to conduct its business. May you richly bless our nation and our state. In the precious name of Jesus Christ, our Lord, I pray. Amen.

[00:27:33] Amen. I pledge allegiance to the flag of the United States of America and to the republic for which it stands, one nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

[00:28:07] The clerk will call the roll. All those present will vote aye. The clerk will close the roll.

[00:28:23] You have a quorum, Madam President. Senate Journal for Monday, January 19, 2026. The senator from Prince Edward County moves that the reading of the journals be waived. The question is, shall the reading of the journals be waived?

[00:28:40] As many as are in favor of the motion will record their votes aye, and those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Does any senator desire to change their vote?

[00:28:56] The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 33, noes 4. Ayes 33, noes 4, the reading of the journals is waived. The clerk will report any communications from the House. The chair calls on the senator from Eastern Fairfax County.

[00:29:22] Good afternoon, Madam President. Good afternoon. Madam President, I move that we waive the reading of the communication of the House of Delegates, if you can see me today. Thank you. All those in favor of waiving the reading of the communications, please record your vote "aye" or say "record your vote aye."

[00:29:44] Any opposed, no. Thank you. Have all the senators voted? Does any senator desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 33, noes 4. Ayes 33, noes 4. The reading of the communications is waived.

[00:30:02] The clerk will report any communications from the governor. We do not have any Madam President. The chair now calls upon the senator from eastern Fairfax County. Thank you Madam President. Madam President, pursuant to Rule 5 of HJR 29, the scheduling resolution, I move that the special continuing joint order relating to judicial elections be held on Wednesday, January 21,

[00:30:36] 2026 at the conclusion of the morning hour? The question is, pursuant to Rule 5 of H.J.R. 29, the scheduling resolution, shall the special and continuing joint order relating to the judicial elections be held on Wednesday, January 21, 2026 at the conclusion of the morning hour?

[00:30:59] all in favor will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted does any senator desire to change their vote the clerk will close the role ayes 38 no zero ayes 38 no zero the special and continuing joint order will be held on wednesday january 21st 2026 at the conclusion of the morning hour now comes the time in our morning hour when we have the honor of welcoming our distinguished guests who are here with us today

[00:31:36] in the senate gallery. I give my daily reminder of our procedure. A senator will stand up and recognize the guests that they have visiting us in the gallery and provide an introduction and then I will provide the welcome of the senate and after that we will all applaud together.

[00:31:59] the chair recognizes the senator from isle of white thank you madam president i rise for an introduction the senator has the floor thank you madam president today our invocation was offered by martin marty lee and i asked that him and his wife sue would stand they joined us today from smithfield virginia where he currently volunteers as chaplain for the isle of white sheriff's office which he has done since april of 2014. he has had various leadership roles within his church community as both a deacon and an elder and maintains his credentials at the international

[00:32:34] Conference of Police Chaplains. In his capacity as chaplain, Marty gives himself humbly supporting the faith, wellness, and mental health of first responders throughout our region. His steadfast support of all members of the first responder community is highlighted by his work as a member of the peer support team for all of Iowa County's first responders. In addition to his ministry work, Marty completed a 32-year career in the insurance industry with the American International Group, advancing from field adjuster to vice president of commercial property claims.

[00:33:04] His service to others started by wearing a uniform from an early age. After four years of distinguished military service in the United States Navy as a hospital corpsman, in Norfolk and Portsmouth, he embarked on a career in law enforcement, first as a local police officer and then as a North Carolina state trooper.

[00:33:20] We won't hold it against him that was North Carolina. He pursued his education at Fayetteville State University and Gaston Community College in North Carolina. And today, Marty continues to walk in his lifelong commitment to service, faith, and community. I hope it will be the pleasure of the Senate to provide a warm welcome to Martin Marty Lee. Thank you, Madam President. Thank you. I thank the Senator for the lovely introduction and Chaplain Lee. And if your wife, Sue, will please stand. We thank you so much.

[00:33:56] We thank you so much for your service, your dedication to your community, and all the inspiration that you share with everyone that you work with. Thank you very much. I ask that the Senate give the warm welcome to our Chaplain who provided our invocation this morning. The chair now recognizes the Senator from Portsmouth. Good morning hour to you,

[00:34:34] Madam President. Good morning. If you will indulge me, I rise for the purposes of two introductions. The Senator has the floor. Thank you. It is my honor to introduce the NAACP Virginia State Conference under the leadership of President Reverend Cozy Bailey and Youth and College Division President Jeline Vince. This dedicated organization has tirelessly advocated for vital issues including affordable housing, equitable health care access, quality education, criminal justice reform, environmental justice, immigration rights, and voter protections. They have also supported four critical constitutional amendments: the restoration of rights, women's reproductive

[00:35:12] of freedom, marriage equality, and fair elections in Virginia through redistricting. Thanks to their efforts, Black Virginians turned out in remarkable numbers, achieving a 92% turnout in the November 2025 election. The work continues as they prepare for upcoming elections, ensuring that every voice is heard and every vote counts.

[00:35:31] Please join me in welcoming the members of the Virginia NAACP Conference. As a reminder, Senator from Portsmouth, are you issuing the same reminder that I'm issuing?

[00:35:54] As a reminder to our guests in the gallery, after the Senator provides the introduction, then I say a few words, and then we all applaud together once we are finished. So thank you for your enthusiasm. These are wonderful guests that we are all recognizing today.

[00:36:13] The Senator from Portsmouth, thank you so much for your wonderful introduction. for our guests from the NAACP. I thank our guests for joining us. Thank you for coming to speak to all of our legislators, and thank you for being a part of this very special day of session.

[00:36:30] Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to our guests from the NAACP.

[00:36:47] - Madam President, if I may continue. - The Senator has the floor. - Madam President, in the gallery today, and I ask them to stand, are the board members of the Virginia Business Higher Education Council. They're here for the annual Legislative Day. The Council is a partnership of business and community leaders from across the Commonwealth and leaders of our public and private colleges and universities and our community colleges. This partnership is one of the big reasons Virginia's Higher Education System is the nation's best, earning top national rankings for

[00:37:25] everything from graduation rates to return on investments. Madam President, recent J-LOC report on higher education showed that our colleges and universities have been excellent partners in using increased state support to make college more affordable. Our schools are also incredibly efficient. North Carolina, Tennessee, Georgia, and Maryland all spend considerably more per student than Virginia, yet those states don't have the top national ranking for quality graduation rates, and ROI we do. But we can all agree there's more work to do.

[00:38:02] such as making two- and four-year college degrees, industry reorganized credentials affordable to all Virginians, providing students with good paid internships along the way, and keeping them in Virginia for full-time work at the graduation. Recently, members received new impact agenda booklets, which shows our investment in higher education are producing values for the people of Virginia, and now and how we prioritize investments that increase that impact in the years ahead. Now I don't want to spill the beans but I'm going to

[00:38:37] spill the beans. Next Monday our new governor and many of us will be joining these and other business leaders to launch a big statewide push on internships. The goal is to get more Virginia employers large and small to start and expand internship programs so there's opportunity for young people all across our state. I know we all appreciate the important work that our business leaders and committee presidents are doing together to create growth and opportunity throughout this Commonwealth and I hope it will be the pleasure of this body to give them the very warm welcome of

[00:39:14] the Senate. I thank the senator from Portsmouth for that comprehensive introduction and as enthusiastic as you are about the impact report and what we are seeing now as we plan to launch this internship opportunity, the coalition and the partnership between our business leaders and our

institutions of higher education is truly remarkable. I thank you for joining us in the Senate gallery today and I especially am looking forward to the announcement next week, no longer a secret, but thank you so much. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome

[00:39:54] of the Senate to the Virginia Business Higher Education Council. The chair calls on the Senator from Norfolk thank you madam chair um madam president um in the gallery um and don't leave dr j don't leave in the gallery i rise for the purpose of an introduction the senator has the floor thank you in the gallery with the council are two of my presidents in the 21st senate

[00:40:32] district dr giovanni gattams astin pre gaston president of the norfolk state university and the president of my alumni dr brian hempel from old dominion university thank you all for being here thank you for that introduction and again welcome to uh the senate gallery welcome to the capitol thank you for your leadership and the work that you are doing on behalf of the institutions senators i ask that we give the warm welcome of the senate to these higher education leaders

[00:41:07] president i have another introduction the senator has the floor thank you madam president um today in the gallery we have members from virginia's oldest funeral service association with us the virginia funeral directors association will be 138 years old this year they have been here for more they have been here for more time they have been here more okay we can't get this right

[00:41:43] They have been here for more than most of the time of existence of our nation. I don't know if I got that right. Today, they are visiting as constituents of members of the General Assembly. The Virginia Funeral Directors Association aims to be the most trusted resource for funeral service providers, communities, and even the General Assembly in Virginia.

[00:42:08] They strive to bring innovation to their profession, provide solutions to critical issues when needed and demonstrate unparalleled professionalism when serving grieving families and the loved ones trusted into their care. Madam President, please join me in giving them the warm welcome of the Senate to the Virginia Funeral Directors Association.

[00:42:32] - I thank the Senator from Norfolk for that introduction and thank you to the Virginia Funeral Directors Association for joining us. I believe I understood the Senator correctly that the Funeral Directors Association has been committed to its communities longer than the Commonwealth has been in existence.

[00:42:51] So that's pretty amazing. But thank you so much for being here in the gallery today. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the Virginia Funeral Directors Association.

[00:43:10] The chair recognizes the Senator from Eastern, Prince William. - Madam President, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. - The Senator has the floor. - Thank you, Madam President. Today I'm pleased to introduce a group of citizen advocates from around the state who have come to participate in Virginia's fourth Democracy Day.

[00:43:32] Nearly 130 citizens have registered for this event and many are here in the gallery representing a dozen nonpartisan organizations involved in good governance. These groups include Big Money Out Virginia, the League of Women Voters, Up Vote Virginia, clean Virginia veterans for all voters and others.

[00:43:52] They are here today to urge us to support legislation that makes our government more responsive to and reflective of everyday Virginians. They believe that in order to seriously address issues

facing our society, we need to change the way our government works. Their priority good governance legislation includes a focus on campaign finance reform with bills ranging from enhancing disclosure of independent expenditures, more transparency and reporting, public financing of elections, and limits on contributions.

[00:44:21] In addition, they would like legislators to support ethics reform, ranked choice voting, and protection of voting rights. These reforms have widespread support for Virginians across the Commonwealth and across party lines. Let this be the year when the state legislator takes the steps needed to increase the confidence and trust of our citizens.

[00:44:39] Thank you all for being citizen advocates, for strengthening our democracy. I ask that we give them a warm Senate welcome. I thank the Senator for that introduction. And if members will please stand, thank you so much for joining us in the gallery.

[00:44:55] Thank you for being here at the Capitol today and your advocacy on many, many critical issues. I hope you have enjoyable visits and conversations with your legislators today. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the organization that is joining us, Big Money Out.

[00:45:13] Thank you. The chair now recognizes the Senator from Arlington. - Good afternoon, Madam President.

[00:45:30] I rise for the purposes of an introduction. - The Senator has the floor. - Thank you, Madam President. Today in the gallery, we have the Virginia Nurses Association with representatives from Marymount University and Bright Point and Germana Community College, and I'm sure other universities are represented as well.

[00:45:51] And the Virginia Nurses Association has brought with them some students. there is also a Virginia Student Nurses Association. So they're visiting our offices and I do hope that we welcome our nurses and our nursing students.

[00:46:07] It's amazing that our nursing students really do have such great mentors and are trying to learn the public policy process because they're bringing knowledge of patient needs and how those patient needs might intersect with the laws we are making.

[00:46:25] I do want to note that the director of the Virginia Nursing Workforce Center is accompanying the group and the Workforce Center, as you know, is under our Virginia Health Workforce Authority. I do hope it is the will of the Senate to give these two groups a warm Senate welcome.

[00:46:43] Thank you, Madam President. I thank the senator from Arlington for that introduction. Thank you so much to all of our individuals who are here today from the Virginia Nurses Association, from the student nurses, the representatives from Marymount University, as well as the Virginia Nursing Workforce Center. Your work is so critical and very, very vital for the health and welfare for all of our communities. Thank you for the work that you are doing. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to these members who are

[00:47:18] here today seeing no further introductions resolutions petitions and bills are now in order

[00:47:34] loud noise the chair calls on the senator from eastern fairfax county is that better the clerk

[00:48:06] will call the calendar my apologies senate calendar for tuesday january 20th 2026 uncontested calendar Senate bill on second reading, Senate bill 95, a bill relating to rest areas, signage, human

trafficking information reported from the committee on transportation with amendments.

[00:48:34] The chair calls on the Senator from Western Prince William. Thank you Madam President, Madam President, I move the committee amendment. The question is, shall the amendment, shall the committee amendment be agreed to?

[00:48:52] This is a voice vote. All in favor, please say aye. Any opposed? No. amendment is agreed to. The Chair calls on the Senator from Western Prince William. Thank you Madam President. Madam President, I move the bill be engrossed in advance to its third reading. The question is, shall the bill be engrossed in advance to its third reading? All in favor, please say aye. Any opposed? No. The bill is engrossed in advance to its third reading. Regular calendar. Senate

[00:49:31] bills on second reading. The Chair calls on the Senator from York. Thank you, Madam Chair, I move that the amendments be agreed to. The question is, shall the amendment from the Committee on Transportation be agreed to? All in favor, please say aye. Any opposed, say no.

[00:50:00] The committee amendments from the Committee on Transportation is agreed to. Madam President, I move that the bill be engrossed in advance to its third reading. The question is, shall the bill be engrossed in advance to its third reading? All those in favor will say aye.

[00:50:20] Any opposed? Say no. The bill is engrossed in advance to its third reading. Senate Bill 81, relating to enforcement of federal traffic infractions by state and local law enforcement officers, photo speed monitoring devices, planning District 8.

[00:50:38] Reported from the Committee on Transportation, and there is a floor amendment. The chair calls on the senator from Eastern Fairfax County. Thank you, Madam President. Move to waive reading of the floor amendment. The question is, shall the reading of the floor amendment be waived?

[00:50:54] All those in favor, please say aye. Any opposed? No. The reading of the floor amendment is waived. The Senator from Eastern Fairfax County. Thank you, Madam President. I'd move the floor amendment and speak to that motion. The Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President.

[00:51:09] Ladies and gentlemen, the Senate, this is a bill we passed last year. And after it came out of the Courts Committee on last week, or the Transportation Committee, I'm sorry, on Thursday, the Supreme Court came to me and said they wanted to make this one clarification that when a Virginia uniform summons is issued that its state the local offense it's violated like the speeding statute that's violated or DUI or whatever that it be specifically stated on the charging document that's basically all all this does that as we adopt it the question is

[00:51:46] shall the floor amendment be agreed to all those in favor please say aye any opposed say no. The floor amendment is adopted. The chair calls on the senator from Eastern Fairfax County. Thank you, Madam President. I've moved the bill be engrossed in advance to his third reading. The question is, shall the bill be engrossed in advance to his third reading? All those in favor will say aye. Any opposed? No. The bill is engrossed in advance to his third reading.

[00:52:21] Uncontested calendar Senate bills on first reading. The chair calls on the senator from Eastern Fairfax County. Sorry, Madam President. Madam President, I that all the senate bills on first reading on the uncontested regular counters pages three through seven senate bills 86 to 137 the rules be suspended in the first constitutional reading the titles be dispensed with the question is shall the rules be suspended

and the first constitutional reading of the titles of senate bills on the uncontested and regular calendars pages three through seven

[00:53:00] senate bill 86 through senate bill 137 be dispensed with all those in favor of the motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their votes the clerk will close the roll ayes 40 no zero ayes 40 no zero the reading of the titles is dispensed with chair calls on the senator from eastern fairfax

[00:53:36] county thank you madam president with all the bills goodbye for the day the question is shall the senate bills on the uncontested and regular calendars now on second reading be passed by for the day all in favor of the motion will say aye those opposed no the ayes have it the bills will go by for the day the senator from eastern fairfax county inquiry the clerk does that complete

[00:54:05] today's calendar yes sir thank you madam we will return now to the morning hour and the chair calls on the senator from arlington thank you madam president i rise again for the purposes of an introduction the senator has the floor uh thank you madam president uh a group called the council of Independent Colleges of Virginia is with us in the audience. This organization represents 28 of

[00:54:45] Virginia's nonprofit private colleges and universities. The leaders, the presidents, and senior leaders of these colleges are here to talk about the need to increase the tuition assistance grant program for the students that are attending their colleges and universities.

[00:55:05] Joining us in the Senate would be the, I think, the President of Marymount University, Ferrum College, Eastern Mennonite University, Southern Virginia University, and Regent University. So I ask that the Senate give the Presidents and their staff a warm welcome. Thank you.

[00:55:24] Thank the Senator for that introduction, and thank the visitors from the Council of independent colleges of virginia thank you again for the representation you are providing to your institutions and to all of our independent colleges i ask that the senators give the warm welcome of the senate to the members of the council of independent colleges of virginia

[00:55:49] and returning still to the morning hour the chair calls on the senator from york thank you madam president i rise for an introduction the senator has the floor thank you i would like to introduce representatives of the Virginia Symphony to the Senate. I'd like to welcome the President and CEO Shannon Kelly and Vice President of Development Susan Bjorn to

[00:56:26] the Senate. In its 105th season the Virginia Symphony Orchestra is one of the finest symphony orchestras in the United States and is in the top 50 sympathies in the country. The VSO supplements music education in 14 school districts including an evidence-based education partnership with carnegie hall it also generates over 12 million dollars in economic activity for the hampton roads area annually and over 800 000 in state and local tax revenue it is my honor to recognize this historic and iconic organization to

[00:57:06] the floor today please extend to them the warm welcome of the senate i thank the senator from York for that introduction and I thank the visitors from our Virginia Symphony Orchestra for joining us today. Thank you for what you bring to our communities and the gift of music that you share, especially with our young people. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to our visitors from the Virginia Symphony Orchestra. Is there any other business

[00:57:43] to come before the Senate? The clerk will report any announcements on the desk. Today, January, tuesday january 20th 2026 the committee on privileges and elections will meet 15 minutes after adjournment senate room b gab the committee on agriculture conservation and natural resources will meet 30 minutes after adjournment senate room a gab the finance and appropriations subcommittee on education will meet at 3 30 pm in the senate finance and appropriations room 13th

[00:58:20] floor gab the education and health subcommittee on health will meet at 4 pm senate room c gab tomorrow wednesday january 21st 2026 the finance and appropriations subcommittee on public safety and claims will meet at 7 30 a.m senate finance and appropriations room 13th floor gab the women's legislative roundtable will meet virtually at 8:30 a.m. The Committee on Agriculture and Conservation and Natural Resources Subcommittee on Rural

[00:58:55] Affairs will meet at 9:00 a.m. in Senate Room C, GAB. The Committee on Finance and Appropriations will meet at 9:00 a.m. Senate Room A, GAB. The Democratic Caucus will meet at 11:15 a.m. Senate Room 1, the Capitol. The Republican caucus will meet at 11:30 a.m. in Senate Room 2 of the Capitol. And I have had several inquiries regarding the weather this coming weekend. We are keeping a close eye on the weather between the National Weather Service, Capitol Police,

[00:59:31] and we will let everyone know what the expectations are as soon as we get them. So just to know that we've had a lot of staff, we've had some members inquiring about what we've heard but we are tracking it and we'll keep you informed the chair now recognizes the senator from portsmouth thank you madam president madam president i move that the senate do now adjourn until 12 noon on tomorrow the question is shall the senate adjourn until 12

[01:00:08] noon tomorrow as many as are in favor of the motion will say aye any opposed no the ayes have it the motion is agreed to the senate stands adjourned until 12 noon tomorrow this has been It's been a broadcast by the Senate of Virginia from Richmond, Virginia.

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